

Radcliffe Camera

Location Oxford, England

The rationality of 18th-century English Classicism—exemplified in architecture by simple geometric shapes—is precisely expressed by the circular Radcliffe Camera, designed by James Gibbs.

Completed in 1748, it is simple in its conception and assured in its execution. Its 16-sided ground floor, with alternating pedimented doors and niches, supports a second story with pairs of giant three-quarter columns and, between them, two levels of windows—the upper arched and the lower square. A plain entablature and cornice

above give way to a balustrade, punctuated by pairs of urns over the columns. Atop it all sits a strongly ribbed dome crowned by a lantern.

Wieskirche

Location Bavaria, Germany

No building better encapsulates the Bavarian Rococo than the Wieskirche, built between 1745 and 1754 by the Zimmerman brothers, Johann and Dominikus. Its exterior promises little; internally, it delights and astounds. It is the Rococo at its most uninhibited and self-confident. There is

almost no part of its gleaming white interior that is not animated by elaborate stucco and spreading frescoes. However, there is also almost no part that does not follow a precise, liturgically dictated color scheme. If it is an interior that revels in decorative delights, it is no less one in which the religious intent is clear.

▼ GOLD-CLAD EXTERIOR OF THE CATHERINE PALACE

Catherine Palace

Location Tsarskoe Selo, Russia

The emergence of Russia, sparked by the energetic reforms of Peter the Great (r.1682–1725), was underlined by the construction of a series of vast imperial buildings in and around the new Russian capital of St. Petersburg. Among the most sumptuous and impressive is the Catherine Palace, built for the Empress Elizabeth, between 1752 and 1756. It was designed by Bartolomeo Rastrelli, the architect of the Winter Palace at St. Petersburg (see p.176). The building's extravagant magnificence is

